

Consent Form

School of Computing and Information Systems

Technology Innovation Project



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Name of Participant: _____

1. I consent to participate in this project, the details of which have been explained to me, and I have been provided with a written plain language statement to keep.
2. I understand that the purpose of this research is to **investigate how individuals seek and provide local help within their communities, and to evaluate the potential of a digital platform to improve accessibility, trust, and efficiency in connecting people with local support services.**
3. I understand that my participation in this project is for research purposes only.
4. I acknowledge that the possible effects of participating in this research project have been explained to my satisfaction.
5. In this project I will be required to **participate in a short interview or survey about my experiences with seeking or offering local help, and I may be asked to provide feedback on a prototype or concept of a digital platform.**
6. I understand that my interviews may be audio recorded.
7. I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw from this project anytime without explanation or prejudice and to withdraw any unprocessed data that I have provided.
8. I have been informed that the confidentiality of the information I provide will be safeguarded subject to any legal requirements; my data will be password protected and accessible only by the named researchers.
9. I understand that given the small number of participants involved in the study, it may not be possible to guarantee my anonymity.
10. I understand that after I sign and return this consent form, it will be retained by the student researchers.

Participant Signature: _____ **Date:** _____

Interview Guide — Australia Hero

Estimated duration: 20–30 minutes **Format:** Semi-structured (follow up naturally on interesting answers)

Opening Script (read aloud)

"Hi, thanks for taking the time to speak with us today. We're a group of postgraduate students from the University of Melbourne working on a project called Australia Hero — a hyper-local platform that helps community members and students exchange small tasks and resources nearby. Before we start, you'll have received our Plain Language Statement explaining the project. Do you have any questions about it? [Pause] Great. I'd also like to ask your permission to audio record this conversation so we can review it later — is that okay? [Pause for consent form signing] Let's begin."

Section 1 — Background (3–4 min)

Goal: understand who the person is and their living context.

1. Can you tell me a bit about yourself — what you're studying or doing, and how long you've been living in your current area?
 2. How would you describe your relationship with your neighbours or the people around you?
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Section 2 — Current Behaviours (5–7 min)

Goal: uncover real, recent experiences — not hypotheticals.

3. Think about the last time you needed help with something small — maybe borrowing something, moving a piece of furniture, or running an errand. What did you do?
 - *Follow up: Why did you choose that approach? Did it work out?*
4. Have you ever had a moment where you needed help but didn't know who to ask, or felt uncomfortable asking? Can you walk me through that situation?
5. Have you ever helped someone nearby — a neighbour, classmate, or stranger? What was that like?
 - *Follow-up: What motivated you to help? Would you do it again?*

Section 3 — Challenges & Pain Points (5 min)

Goal: validate and deepen the problem.

6. When you try to find help — whether through apps, social media, or friends — what's the most frustrating part of that process?
 7. Have you ever used a platform like Facebook groups, Nextdoor, or WhatsApp groups to ask for or offer help? What worked well, and what didn't?
 8. As an international student or someone new to the area, have you ever felt you lacked a local support network for small everyday things? Can you give an example?
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Section 4 — Reactions to the Platform Idea (5–7 min)

Goal: gauge genuine interest and surface concerns.

[Brief explanation: "Our platform lets you post small help requests on a map — like borrowing a tool or asking for help moving a box — and nearby people can respond. There's also a reputation and reward system to build trust."]

9. What's your initial reaction to this idea?
 10. Can you imagine a situation in your own life where you'd actually use something like this? What would that look like?
 11. What would make you hesitant to use it — or stop using it after trying it once?
 - *Follow up: What would need to be true for you to feel safe interacting with a stranger through this platform?*
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Section 5 — Trust, Safety & Incentives (5 min)

Goal: understand what builds confidence and motivates participation.

12. What would make you trust someone enough to accept help from them or offer help to them on this platform?
13. If there were a points or reputation system — where you earned recognition for helping — would that motivate you, or would it feel artificial? Why?
14. Would you prefer to remain somewhat anonymous on this platform, or would you want your real identity visible? What's your reasoning?
15. When receiving help or offering help, do you have any personal preferences regarding the helper or requester (e.g., gender, age, or other factors)?

- *Follow up:* Do you feel more comfortable interacting with someone of a particular gender in certain situations? (describe the situation)
16. Does this preference also apply when you are the one offering help to others?
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Section 6 — Feature Priorities (3 min)

Goal: prioritise MVP features based on real user input.

17. If you could only have two or three features on this platform when it first launched, what would they be and why?
18. Is there anything you've seen in another app — not necessarily in this space — that you think would work really well here?
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Closing (1–2 min)

19. Is there anything else about this kind of platform — or your own experiences with getting or giving help — that you think we should know?

"Thank you so much for your time. Your answers are really valuable to us. Just as a reminder, your responses will be kept confidential, referred to by a pseudonym in any reporting, and you can withdraw at any time. We'll be in touch if we have any follow-up questions."

Tips for Your Team

Before the interview: Have the Consent Form and Plain Language Statement ready. Let the participant read the PLS first, then sign the consent form before recording begins.

During: Don't rush past good stories — if someone gives a rich example, ask "can you tell me more about that?" The best insights come from specifics, not generalities.

Divide and conquer: One person asks questions, another takes notes. Rotate roles across interviews.

Target participants: Prioritise international students for interviews, as your proposal identifies them as the primary user group with the most acute pain points.